

The railways in India had not been immune to the strain of World War II. The myth of benign British imperialism had meanwhile crumbled and independence became the rallying cry across the country. Canadian historian Ian J Kerr wrote in his book *Engines of Change*, "The rolling stock and infrastructure of India's railroads were badly depleted. Many British railroad men had left India to serve the British war effort and they, seeing the end of the Raj, did not return. The Indianization of the upper levels of railroad service was thereby advanced – a positive development given the severe test to which the railroads were soon to be put."

Even amid growing suspicions that these were the closing years of colonial rule in India, it was business as usual for the railways. Post-war repairs and demands for rolling stock were being addressed, matters concerning its staff were being looked into, and its capital and depreciation fund estimates were being calculated. The chief commissioner of the railways in his Budget speech for 1944–45 continued to make plans: "At the end of the war there will be much to be done in the rehabilitation of the existing assets and in the development of the railways..."

Turning a profit

The period of 1946–47 saw a significant percentage increase in upper-class and interclass passenger traffic. In fact, the continuing swell in passenger traffic made the railways curtail its expenditure on publicity campaigns. The changing political landscape notwithstanding, the enterprise continued to make a profit. In a Budget speech for 1945–46, War Transport Member Sir Edward Benthall reported enthusiastically that the figures for the Budget were "judged by pre-war figures, phenomenal ..." and that, "the railways despite its war-usage and on the brink of finding itself in the hands of the natives had thrived and continued to grow."

The Budget speech for 1946–47 was also optimistic: "... financially the position is far sounder than it has been at any stage in the history of the railways ... Lower class travel has not been comfortable in the past because the main consideration has been the provision of cheap travel